

Altec Lansing XA3021

2.1 for the price of 4.1

The XA3021 speaker set is designed to stick out in a crowd. The subwoofer looks like a 500 pound bomb, a scuba diving apparatus, or an ultra-futuristic cappuccino machine, depending on which angle you look at it from. The satellites are designed to look like large stu-



dio microphones, with the ability to swivel vertically.

The wired remote control has three presets to control the bass level—TV, Gaming and Max Bass. The traditional volume control is replaced by a rotary dial that can change volume levels really quickly. However, if you're looking to turn down the volume a wee bit, it'll actually increase significantly before going down.

The speaker connections are different from what you'd expect—instead of inputs for the front and subwoofer channels, it has Left and Right

channel inputs; typical of TVs. PC users should be aware that the sound card output needs to go into the 'Aux' Input for the system to work.

The bass is pretty powerful—too powerful at high volumes—and the treble reproduction is truly excellent. It's only at the highest levels that the treble begins to crack, but the bass gives way long before that. In fact, it only sounds good at low to medium volumes. Plastic just can't replace wood as a substitute for a subwoofer's case.

Overall, the speakers perform consistently with what you'd expect from a high-quality set. The real body blow comes if you glance at the price tag. Rs 6,750 is way above its deserved asking price. You can get great-sounding 4.1 speaker sets for less than that. The XA3021 looks like a bomb, and costs just about as much.

SPECIFICATIONS

20 W RMS total power, 35 Hz to 18 KHz frequency response, 76 dB SNR, 5.25-inch long-throw woofer, two 3-inch full-range satellites, corded remote

Altec Lansing XA3021 B	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Build Quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶

Price: Rs 6,750
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SpeedUpMyPC 1.16

Memory monger

Most of us would appreciate a utility which allows us to free precious memory and assign more CPU power to programs. SpeedUpMyPC is a program from Li Utilities that serves this purpose—it help you free up RAM when needed. You get an option to set a limit of



utilised RAM, after which the program will automatically start freeing up memory. You also have an option of 'Deep RAM Recovery', which frees up more memory. It can be used when your system is extremely sluggish, and saves you from restarting.

SpeedUpMyPC is also capable of monitoring CPU resources, and assigning them to the most important tasks. It depicts usage on a graph and allows the user to assign resources to any program currently running. Most importantly, it can also prioritise system processes, once a certain amount of CPU usage is set.

This program is capable of optimising the browser and Internet settings and can also automatically perform a

Price: \$29.99 (approx Rs 1,399)
Contact: Liutilities
E-mail: contact@liutilities.com
Web site: www.liutilities.com

bandwidth test to gauge your speed. However, we did not see any sort of boost in surfing or downloading.

SpeedUpMyPC can recover the PC from crashes. It does this by trying to terminate tasks that are possibly responsible for the crash, frees up the CPU and RAM, and restarts the Windows shell.

Overall, SpeedUpMyPC 1.16 does offer a good set of features and will boost system performance for those who use older versions of Windows, such as Windows 9x.

SPECIFICATIONS

Windows 95, 98, 2000 or XP, 10 MB free hard disk space, 32 MB RAM, Pentium 400 MHz or higher

SpeedUpMyPC 1.16 B+	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Ease of Use	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶

BenQ M100 Optical Mouse

Glow mouse

BenQ's new M100 optical two-button scroll mouse, is an entry-level optical input device. The mouse is an elegant electric blue, with silver coating on the buttons.

The M100 is built for both left-handed and right-handed users, and has a USB to PS/2 adapter. It displayed good precision in the games we played, namely, *Unreal Tournament 2003* and *Quake III Arena*. The mouse sensitivity is above par, and performed well even when the mouse sensitivity settings were lowered.

Price: Rs 699
Contact: BenQ India Pvt Ltd
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Web site: www.benq.co.in

Although it costs as much as an entry level mouse, it matches the quality of a Microsoft mouse. It combines top performance and great value in a very attractive package, and is worth every penny you spend, and that's the bottom line!

SPECIFICATIONS

Optical sensor, PS/2 interface (USB version with USB to PS/2 option also available), two buttons, scroll wheel with glowing LED

BenQ M100 Optical Mouse A	
Performance	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Build Quality	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Value for money	▶▶▶▶▶▶
Features	▶▶▶▶▶▶
OVERALL	▶▶▶▶▶▶